Helping students listen and take useful notes

Practical guide for subject lecturers | D05-S1–S6

Contents

1. Provide a simple note-taking framework 1
2. Signal what is important to record 1
3. Show how to turn an explanation into brief notes 2
4. Separate listening from copying 2
5. Build in short pauses to complete notes 3
6. Help students check and improve their notes 3

Supporting sources 4

Students may find it difficult to follow an explanation, decide what matters and write notes at the same time. Help them see what useful notes look like in your subject and provide time to record and check their understanding.

1. Provide a simple note-taking framework

1. Prepare an outline that follows the main topics of your lecture. Include headings and space for students to add explanations, evidence or examples.
2. Before starting, explain how to use it: “The main topics are already listed. Add a short explanation and one example for each. You do not need to record every sentence.”

Example — Public health

Intervention	What does it aim to achieve?	Main supporting evidence	Limitations
Vaccination			
Screening			

Leave enough space for meaningful notes. Avoid creating so many gaps that students spend the lecture searching for missing words.

2. Signal what is important to record

1. Tell students which points they will need in their notes. Distinguish central ideas from examples and additional detail.
   Useful wording includes:

- "The key relationship to record is…"
- "There are three stages. Leave space for a brief note on each."
- "This example illustrates the principle we have just discussed."
- "Record the conclusion and the reason for it."

Example — Economics: "The key point is that purchasing power falls when prices rise faster than income. Record that relationship first. I'll then give you an example."

2. Pause before continuing so students can finish their notes.

3. Show how to turn an explanation into brief notes

1. Choose a short explanation from your teaching.
2. Display a possible set of notes and explain what you selected, shortened or left out.

   Example — Business: "The retailer's revenue increased from £100,000 to £120,000. However, costs increased from £70,000 to £100,000, so profit fell from £30,000 to £20,000."

   Possible notes:

Measure	Previous year	Current year
Revenue	£100,000	£120,000
Costs	£70,000	£100,000
Profit	£30,000	£20,000

   Main point: Revenue ↑, but costs ↑ more → profit ↓.

3. Explain your choices: "The table keeps the figures clear. The final line records the relationship they illustrate. The upward arrow means 'increased', and the final arrow means 'led to'."

Students can use different layouts and abbreviations, provided their notes preserve the meaning and remain understandable later.

4. Separate listening from copying

For a complex explanation, give students a short period to listen and follow the visual before asking them to write.

How to do it

1. Provide or display the diagram, table or worked example.

2. Explain what students should attend to.
3. Give the explanation.
4. Pause while students annotate or summarise it.

Keep the visual available during the pause. Provide detailed diagrams for annotation where possible.

Example — Engineering: “First, follow the current through the circuit as I explain. Then I’ll pause so you can label the fault and note why it interrupts the circuit.”

5. Build in short pauses to complete notes

Pause after a substantial explanation or before moving to a new topic. Give students a specific action.

For example: “Take a minute to finish your notes. Add one sentence explaining why the result changed. Mark anything you need clarified with a question mark.”

Use the pause to look at a few students’ notes. If several have misunderstood the same point, clarify it before continuing.

Students do not need polished sentences. Encourage brief notes that capture complete ideas, including essential subject terms, relationships and qualifications.

6. Help students check and improve their notes

Ask students to compare a small part of their notes in pairs. Give them a focused checking task.

Example — Environmental science: “Compare your notes on mitigation and adaptation. Check that each definition has an appropriate example. Identify any differences you need us to clarify.”

Then display a short teacher outline of the essential content. Ask students to correct or add to their notes.

Explain: “Your wording and layout can differ. Check whether your notes capture the key distinction accurately.”

Resolve disagreements about meaning through explanation or reference to the course material.

A short routine to try

For one section of your next lecture:

1. Provide a heading or simple framework.
2. Signal the central point.
3. Explain it with an example.
4. Pause for students to complete their notes.
5. Ask pairs to check one important relationship.
6. Display a brief outline and clarify any misunderstanding.

Supporting sources

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